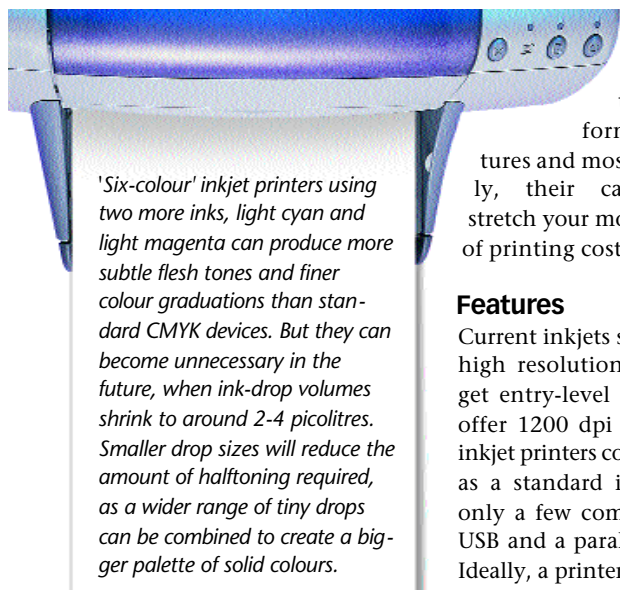




'Six-colour' inkjet printers using two more inks, light cyan and light magenta can produce more subtle flesh tones and finer colour graduations than standard CMYK devices. But they can become unnecessary in the future, when ink-drop volumes shrink to around 2-4 picolitres. Smaller drop sizes will reduce the amount of halftoning required, as a wider range of tiny drops can be combined to create a bigger palette of solid colours.

each of the printers fared in terms of performance, features and most importantly, their capability to stretch your money in terms of printing costs.

Features

Current inkjets support fairly high resolutions—you even get entry-level printers that offer 1200 dpi prints. Most inkjet printers come with USB as a standard interface but only a few come with both USB and a parallel interface. Ideally, a printer should have support for both so that people

with older PCs don't have a problem connecting the printer. For a truly cost-effective printer, look for features such as LED indicators, ink level status indicators, and bundled accessories such as a data cable and packs of high-quality photo paper. Features that help you check the level of ink in the cartridges will ensure that you get the most out of your ink cartridges. A visual indicator that the printer is out of ink or paper is a great help if you're working away from your PC after having sent a print command. If your printer doesn't have any visual indicators then there's no way to know what's wrong. Also, the ability to check ink levels via the printer drivers is a great way to monitor and manage the consumption of ink.

Absence of accessories such as a data cable can be quite an irritant as you cannot connect the printer to the PC without one and having to buy a data cable adds to the overall cost of a printer.

Other features that will help you save expenses on consumables are support for dual-sided printing, and the number of options available for changing the print resolution. The latter gives you a greater degree of control as you can then choose to print draft documents at lower resolutions and save on ink.

All printers in the budget category had support for USB and supported at least 600 dpi printing. A notable exception was the Canon S200SP, which offered a maximum resolution of 2880x720 dpi, which compares with the kind of resolutions supported by high-end printers. Canon also claims that a printout taken on Canon Photo Paper will stay resistant to the damaging effects of light for up to 25 years. However, there are no LED indicators on the Canon S200SP.

The Canon BJC-2100SP comes with a rather interesting feature which allows you to also use it as a scanner by simply replacing the ink cartridge with the optional IS-22 scanner cartridge and scan colour images at a decent 360 dpi.

The HP Deskjet 656C and the Olivetti Artjet 12 were the only printers that came with 512 KB of cache. The entire Lexmark series of printers in this category had no cache. Although we did not face any problems printing our test pages on these printers, you might experience a slowdown while printing very large images or heavy documents. The HP Deskjet 656C has LED indicators, which alert you in case of a paper jam or when the printer runs out of paper. This was the only model in the budget category to support dual-sided printing, but there was no support for checking the ink level status via the driver.

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